The Goal of a Project

What Do Clients Actually Buy?

The Project Goal

Software engineering projects solve stakeholder problems. Keep that goal in view.

The goal goes beyond **writing code**.

> Deliver measurable value to stakeholders by solving the right problem within agreed constraints.

In short, it is **making clients happy.**

Clients and Stakeholders

Stakeholders = everyone who cares about, or is affected by, the project.

Clients pay for or request the work. Other stakeholders include:

- Leaders (CEO, CTO) who fund and sponsor the work
- Managers & tech leads — your daily audience
- Product owners & sales, who shape and sell the product
- End users, who may or may not be the ones paying

In a class Project:

- Your professor and your teammates are stakeholders.
- Future employers are an audience for your portfolio, rather than project stakeholders.

What Stakeholders Value

Stakeholders value solutions, outcomes, and reduced risk over code itself.

Remember **UP ReST**:

- **U**nderstanding — grasp the real problem behind the request
- **P**eace of mind — handle their problem reliably, without drama
- **Re**duced risk — fewer surprises; safety over low price
- **S**tatus — build their credibility within the organization
- **T**ime — carry the mental load so they can focus elsewhere

Understand their needs, reduce risk, and deliver useful software: **make them happy**.

- Next: understand the problem; deliver outcomes and reduce risk.

Understand the Real Problem

Before jumping to a solution:

- Learn the true goal, not just the literal request
- Learn how the problem started and why it matters
- Identify who's affected, and how

Deliver Outcomes, Reduce Risk

Give stakeholders confidence in project success.

- Be the reliable, safe choice, not just the cheapest one
- Use quick prototypes to reduce uncertainty early
- Reduce their mental load so they can focus on priorities

Build Trust Through Communication

Worst: "Everything's fine" without progress; missing or misleading updates; blame.

Best: Small, steady progress; honest good/bad news; lessons that prevent repeated mistakes.

Recap: Software Engineers Are Professional Problem Solvers

- Solve problems by managing complexity
- Solve problems using tools and rules
- Solve problems as a team
- Earn trust by proving themselves capable problem solvers

Projects prove we can solve real problems and deliver value to clients and stakeholders.